

Post-incident review PIR-2025-046

Customer Portal: intermittent timeouts

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 23 November 2025, Customer Portal experienced intermittent timeouts in production (AU East) for about 110 minutes. Staff in the contact centre noticed the console was slow and told the service owner. Investigation found that an external payment processor changed its response format without warning.

Impact

Users of Customer Portal saw intermittent timeouts for about 110 minutes. The service owner, Digital Channels, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:05 First signal received.
- 09:24 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:45 Likely cause identified.
- 10:01 Mitigation applied.
- 10:57 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that an external payment processor changed its response format without warning.

Certificates were checked as part of triage and were valid.

The expected load had not been tested before release.

The relevant alert had fired repeatedly the previous week and had been muted by the on-call engineer.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Add a pre-deployment check that validates the setting against the production baseline.
- Review alert thresholds so the alert only fires when action is needed.
- Move certificate renewal into the automated rotation pipeline.